

■■ Elimination by Aspects

■ What is it?

Making choices by eliminating options step by step.

When faced with many options, people narrow them down by cutting out anything that doesn't meet their top priorities.

For example, when buying a laptop, you might first remove all models with less than 16GB RAM, then eliminate ones without SSD storage.

■■ History

The concept was introduced by psychologist **Amos Tversky (1972)** as part of **decision-making theory**.

He showed that people rarely compare every option at once. Instead, they remove choices that fail to meet specific “must-have” criteria, making the process manageable.

■ The Psychology Behind It

- People struggle to compare large sets of options at once.
- So they apply **filters**—removing items that don't fit their needs.
- This makes complex decisions feel simpler and more structured.

The risk is that good options might get eliminated too early if filters are too strict or poorly designed.

■■ Why It Matters

Elimination by aspects can lead to:

- Missed opportunities from hard filters
- Decision fatigue if too many filters are required
- Oversimplified user journeys
- Inflexible or frustrating search results
- Poor outcomes if default filters hide useful options

■ How to Apply It

- **Let users set filters early** → highlight key must-haves.
- **Offer “undo” options** → allow people to reverse eliminations.
- **Support comparisons** → show side-by-side features.
- **Make filters intuitive** → simple, easy-to-update choices.
- **Provide sorting tools** → e.g., “Top Rated” or “Best Value.”
- **Progressive disclosure** → reveal more filters as needed.

■ Theory in Action

- **Booking.com** lets users filter hotels by essentials like “Free Wi-Fi” or “Pet-friendly,” speeding up decisions.
- **Best Buy** shelves use bold spec tags like “4K” or “OLED” so customers can filter visually in-store.

■ Final Thought

People simplify decisions by cutting out what doesn't fit their needs.

Good UX supports this process by giving users **flexible, clear, and reversible filters**, helping them find the right choice without losing hidden gems.